Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Modern Art & Ideas

Module 2
Places & Spaces

Module 3
Art & Identity

Module 4
Transforming Everyday Objects

Introduction to Transforming Everyday Objects
- Welcome to Module 4 — Reading • 10 min
- Transforming Everyday Objects — Video • 4 min

Transforming How Objects Look
- How do artists draw from their surroundings? — Reading • 20 min
- Ruth Asawa. Untitled (BMC. 145, BMC Laundry Stamp). c. 1948-49 — Video • 1 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Noah Purifoy. Unknown. 1967 — Video • 2 min

Transforming What Objects Mean
- **How do artists alter the meaning of objects?** — Reading • 10 min
- Alfonso Ossorio. Empty Chair or The Last Colonial. 1969 — Video • 2 min
- Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- Diamond Stingily. Entryways. 2021 — Video • 1 min

Transforming What Objects Do
- How do designers problem-solve? — Reading • 10 min
- Clara Porset. Butaque Chair. 1957 — Video • 2 min
- Tomás Gabzdil Libertíny. The Honeycomb Vase "Made by Bees" (Prototype). 2006 — Video • 2 min

Review & Reflect
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min
- Assessment:Transforming Everyday Objects — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Prompts for Discussion & Reflection — Reading • 10 min

Module 5
Module 5: Art & Society

Module 6
Course Conclusion

How do artists alter the meaning of objects?

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Marcel Duchamp. *Bicycle Wheel*. 1951 (third version, after lost original of 1913). Metal wheel mounted on painted wood stool, 51 x 25 x 16 1/2" (129.5 x 63.5 x 41.9 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. The Sidney and Harriet Janis Collection. © 2016 Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York/ADAGP, Paris/Estate of Marcel Duchamp

Like his fellow Dada artists, Marcel Duchamp questioned long-held assumptions about what art should be and how it should be made. In the years immediately preceding World War I, he found success as a painter. But he soon gave up painting almost entirely, explaining, "I was interested in ideas—not merely in visual products."

In this spirit, he began selecting mass-produced, commercially available, and often utilitarian items, designating them as art, and giving them titles. These readymades, as he called them, disrupted centuries of thinking about the artist's role as a skilled creator of original, handmade objects. Instead, he argued that "an ordinary object [could be] elevated to the dignity of a work of art by the mere choice of an artist." Duchamp claimed he selected objects regardless of "good or bad taste," defying the notion that art must be pleasing to the eye.



Betye Saar. *Black Girl's Window*. 1969. Wooden window frame with paint, cut-and-pasted printed and painted papers, daguerreotype, lenticular print, and plastic figurine. 35 3/4 x 18 x 1 1/2" (90.8 x 45.7 x 3.8 cm). Gift of Candace King Weir through The Modern Women's Fund, and Committee on Painting and Sculpture Funds. © Betye Saar, courtesy the artist and Roberts Projects, Los Angeles

Saar made *Black Girl's Window* in the first decade of her career, marking the moment when her practice shifted from primarily printmaking, to collage and assemblage. The work weaves together references to the private, the public, and the mystical. A salvaged wooden window frame surrounds a series of nine small vignettes in the upper half of the composition. Under depictions of stars and phases of the moon are a phrenological chart, a representation of Leo (Saar's astrological sign), a daguerreotype, and, in the center, a pair of skeletons.

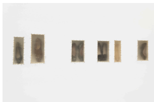
Below is a large silhouetted figure with two eyes cut from a lenslike material that creates the illusion that they open and close. Saar has acknowledged the self-referential nature of the assemblage: "Even at the time, I knew it was autobiographical," she has said. "We'd had the Watts Riots and the Black revolution. Also that was the year of my divorce. So in addition to the occult subject matter there was political and also personal content."



John Outterbridge. *Strange Fruit, Containment Series*. 1969. Metal, paint, and wood. 10 1/2 × 12 × 1 3/4" (26.7 × 30.5 × 4.5 cm). Gift of Jerry I. Speyer and Katherine Farley in honor of Marie-Josée and Henry R. Kravis. © 2024 John Outterbridge. Courtesy of the Artist

The materials John Outterbridge used to make this work began as discarded objects picked up off the streets of his South Central Los Angeles neighborhood. For Outterbridge, making art from everyday things provided a direct means of becoming involved with his environment. As he has explained, "The work engaged part of the experience of the reinvention of things." The artist's niece, Architecture and Black Studies professor Mabel O. Wilson adds, "My grandfather had a salvaging business. My grandmother was a seamstress. A worn out pair of jeans becomes a quilt, or the parts of the pig that aren't the most valuable, those become a delicacy or part of an amazing dish. So that assemblage sensibility is a part of a kind of family, cultural history of making do."

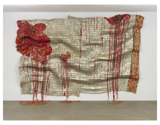
The work's title, *Strange Fruit*, references Billie Holiday's song about lynching in the south. Wilson observes, "Just talking about white supremacy and oppression is one thing, but that's not the sum total of the ways in which Black people experience and make their world, and I think that was something that I understood and learned from my uncle John Outterbridge's work."



Doris Salcedo. *Atrabilious*. 1992–93. Wall installation with plywood, shoes, cow bladder, and surgical thread, six niches, overall 30 x 70 x 5 1/8" (76.2 x 178.4 x 13 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Marie-Josée and Henry R. Kravis. © 2016 Doris Salcedo

Doris Salcedo describes herself as a "secondary witness" to the protracted civil war in Colombia. She makes work that honors its hundreds of thousands of victims and that confronts those who perpetrate these conflicts. In *Atrabilious* (which means melancholy or ill temper) she encased worn women's shoes, singly and in pairs, in niches covered over with a scrim made from stretched cow's bladder.

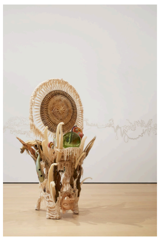
The shoes stand in for the people who have disappeared over the course of the conflict. Seen behind their murky, membranous coverings, the shoes appear as old photographs or saintly relics. "I cannot fix any problem[s]. I can do nothing. It's a lack of power," Salcedo has said. "But then as a person who lacks power, I face the ones who have power and who manipulate life. It's from that perspective—of the one who lacks power—that I look at the powerful ones and at their deeds."



El Anatsui. *Bleeding Takari II*. 2007. Aluminum and copper wire, 12' 11" x 18' 11" (393.7 x 576.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Donald L. Bryant, Jr. and Jerry Speyer

El Anatsui works with wood, clay, and, perhaps most recognizably, salvaged metal liquor bottle caps and seals discarded by Nigerian distilleries. With copper wire and a team of studio assistants, he weaves these crushed and flattened metal pieces into installations, sculptures, and wall hangings. *Bleeding Takari II* combines elements of textiles (especially Ghanaian kente cloth), sculpture, and painting. These works reflect the fraught networks of exchange between Africa, Europe, and America, since liquor was among the key currencies of the slave trade.

Though many have seen references to recycling in these pieces, Anatsui explains that this is not his intention: "Recycling has to do with the industrial process, and that's not what I do. I don't… return the bottle caps back as mere bottle caps. They are given a new life, and [I] make them not objects that do something utilitarian but objects of contemplation."



Guadalupe Maravilla. *Disease Thrower #5*. 2019. Gong, glass, steel, wood, glue mixture, cotton, wood, plastic, loofah, paint, straw, Florida Water, and objects collected from a ritual retracing the artist's original migration route, 91 × 55 × 45" (231.1 × 139.7 × 114.3 cm). Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © Guadalupe Maravilla

Guadalupe Maravilla's *Disease Thrower #5* is a sculpture, a shrine, a wearable headdress, and an acoustic instrument. Like all works in the artist's Disease Thrower series, it is, according to Maravilla, a "healing machine," which can be activated to create a sound bath with curative potential.

It is made from both natural materials, such as straw and loofah, and man-made objects that Maravilla collected while retracing parts of the migratory route from El Salvador to the United States he took as an unaccompanied minor fleeing the civil war. The work also includes anatomical models: one of a dissected breast, and a smaller, cylindrical, colon-like sculpture—that refer to the artist and his mother's experiences with cancer. To Maravilla, trauma and disease are interwoven; he suggests a direct connection between his experiences as a migrant and his cancer.

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